

10th Grade
Term 1
C5 Practice Activity

Evaluated Criterion

C5: Constructs opportunity loss tables and applies the Minimax regret criterion to select the alternative that minimises the maximum opportunity loss.

1 Minimax Regret Criterion

When probabilities are not available, a decision-maker can compare alternatives by considering the opportunity loss, or regret, associated with each possible state of nature. Regret measures the payoff that could have been obtained by choosing the best alternative for the state of nature that actually occurs, minus the payoff obtained from the selected alternative.

For a payoff table with alternatives in rows and states of nature in columns, let $P_{ay}(A_i, S_j)$ represent the payoff obtained when alternative A_i is selected and state of nature S_j occurs.

For each state of nature, first identify the best available payoff:

$$\begin{aligned} b(S_j) &= \max_i P_{ay}(A_i, S_j) \\ &= \max \{P_{ay}(A_1, S_j), P_{ay}(A_2, S_j), \dots, P_{ay}(A_m, S_j)\}. \end{aligned}$$

The regret associated with alternative A_i under state S_j is then

$$r(A_i, S_j) = b(S_j) - P_{ay}(A_i, S_j).$$

For each alternative, determine its maximum possible regret:

$$\begin{aligned} R(A_i) &= \max_j r(A_i, S_j) = \max_j \{b(S_j) - P_{ay}(A_i, S_j)\} \\ &= \max \{r(A_i, S_1), r(A_i, S_2), \dots, r(A_i, S_n)\}. \end{aligned}$$

The Minimax Regret criterion selects the alternative whose maximum regret is as small as possible:

$$A_{\text{Minimax Regret}}^* = \arg \min_i R(A_i).$$

Thus, the procedure is:

Best payoff in each state $\longrightarrow$ Regret table $\longrightarrow$ Maximum regret for each alternative $\longrightarrow$ Minimum of those maximum

The selected alternative minimizes the largest opportunity loss that could result from the decision.

2 General 2x2 Problem

Consider the following payoff table:

Alternative	S_1	S_2
A_1	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_2)$
A_2	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_2)$

Construct the opportunity loss table and determine the decision using the Minimax Regret criterion.

2.1 Solution

Step 1: Identify the best payoff in each state of nature

Under S_1 , compare the payoffs of A_1 and A_2 :

$$b(S_1) = \max \{P_{ay}(A_1, S_1), P_{ay}(A_2, S_1)\}.$$

Under S_2 , compare the payoffs of A_1 and A_2 :

$$b(S_2) = \max \{P_{ay}(A_1, S_2), P_{ay}(A_2, S_2)\}.$$

Therefore,

$$b(S_1) = \max \{P_{ay}(A_1, S_1), P_{ay}(A_2, S_1)\},$$

$$b(S_2) = \max \{P_{ay}(A_1, S_2), P_{ay}(A_2, S_2)\}.$$

Step 2: Construct the opportunity loss table

For each alternative and state of nature, subtract the payoff from the best payoff available under that state:

$$r(A_i, S_j) = b(S_j) - P_{ay}(A_i, S_j).$$

Thus,

$$r(A_1, S_1) = b(S_1) - P_{ay}(A_1, S_1),$$

$$r(A_1, S_2) = b(S_2) - P_{ay}(A_1, S_2),$$

$$r(A_2, S_1) = b(S_1) - P_{ay}(A_2, S_1),$$

$$r(A_2, S_2) = b(S_2) - P_{ay}(A_2, S_2).$$

Step 3: Find the maximum regret for each alternative

For A_1 ,

$$R(A_1) = \max \{r(A_1, S_1), r(A_1, S_2)\}.$$

For A_2 ,

$$R(A_2) = \max \{r(A_2, S_1), r(A_2, S_2)\}.$$

Therefore,

$$R(A_1) = \max \{b(S_1) - P_{ay}(A_1, S_1), b(S_2) - P_{ay}(A_1, S_2)\},$$

$$R(A_2) = \max \{b(S_1) - P_{ay}(A_2, S_1), b(S_2) - P_{ay}(A_2, S_2)\}.$$

Step 4: Apply the Minimax Regret criterion

Compare the maximum regrets:

$$R^* = \min \{R(A_1), R(A_2)\}.$$

The Minimax Regret decision is

$$A_{\text{Minimax Regret}}^* = \arg \min_i \{R(A_i)\}.$$

Thus, choose A_1 if $R(A_1) < R(A_2)$, choose A_2 if $R(A_2) < R(A_1)$, and report a tie if $R(A_1) = R(A_2)$.

Opportunity loss table

Alternative	S_1	S_2	Maximum Regret
A_1	$r(A_1, S_1)$	$r(A_1, S_2)$	$R(A_1)$
A_2	$r(A_2, S_1)$	$r(A_2, S_2)$	$R(A_2)$

3 General 4x3 Problem

Consider the following payoff table:

Alternative	S_1	S_2	S_3
A_1	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_3)$
A_2	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_3)$
A_3	$P_{ay}(A_3, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_3, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_3, S_3)$
A_4	$P_{ay}(A_4, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_4, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_4, S_3)$

Determine the decision using both the Maximax and Maximin criteria.

3.1 Solution

Step 1: Identify the alternatives and states of nature

Alternatives: A_1, A_2, A_3, A_4 States of nature: S_1, S_2, S_3 .

Step 2: Calculate the Maximax values

For each alternative, identify its highest possible payoff:

$$M_1 = \max \{P_{ay}(A_1, S_1), P_{ay}(A_1, S_2), P_{ay}(A_1, S_3)\},$$

$$M_2 = \max \{P_{ay}(A_2, S_1), P_{ay}(A_2, S_2), P_{ay}(A_2, S_3)\},$$

$$M_3 = \max \{P_{ay}(A_3, S_1), P_{ay}(A_3, S_2), P_{ay}(A_3, S_3)\},$$

$$M_4 = \max \{P_{ay}(A_4, S_1), P_{ay}(A_4, S_2), P_{ay}(A_4, S_3)\}.$$

Compare the four maximum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximax}}^* = \arg \max_i M_i.$$

Thus, choose the alternative with the highest possible payoff.

Step 3: Calculate the Maximin values

For each alternative, identify its lowest possible payoff:

$$m_1 = \min \{P_{ay}(A_1, S_1), P_{ay}(A_1, S_2), P_{ay}(A_1, S_3)\},$$

$$m_2 = \min \{P_{ay}(A_2, S_1), P_{ay}(A_2, S_2), P_{ay}(A_2, S_3)\},$$

$$m_3 = \min \{P_{ay}(A_3, S_1), P_{ay}(A_3, S_2), P_{ay}(A_3, S_3)\},$$

$$m_4 = \min \{P_{ay}(A_4, S_1), P_{ay}(A_4, S_2), P_{ay}(A_4, S_3)\}.$$

Compare the four minimum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximin}}^* = \arg \max_i m_i.$$

Thus, choose the alternative with the highest worst-case payoff.

Extended payoff table

Alternative	S_1	S_2	S_3	Max	Min
A_1	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_1, S_3)$	$\max\{P_{ay}(A_1, S_1), P_{ay}(A_1, S_2), P_{ay}(A_1, S_3)\}$	$\min\{P_{ay}(A_1, S_1), P_{ay}(A_1, S_2), P_{ay}(A_1, S_3)\}$
A_2	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_2, S_3)$	$\max\{P_{ay}(A_2, S_1), P_{ay}(A_2, S_2), P_{ay}(A_2, S_3)\}$	$\min\{P_{ay}(A_2, S_1), P_{ay}(A_2, S_2), P_{ay}(A_2, S_3)\}$
A_3	$P_{ay}(A_3, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_3, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_3, S_3)$	$\max\{P_{ay}(A_3, S_1), P_{ay}(A_3, S_2), P_{ay}(A_3, S_3)\}$	$\min\{P_{ay}(A_3, S_1), P_{ay}(A_3, S_2), P_{ay}(A_3, S_3)\}$
A_4	$P_{ay}(A_4, S_1)$	$P_{ay}(A_4, S_2)$	$P_{ay}(A_4, S_3)$	$\max\{P_{ay}(A_4, S_1), P_{ay}(A_4, S_2), P_{ay}(A_4, S_3)\}$	$\min\{P_{ay}(A_4, S_1), P_{ay}(A_4, S_2), P_{ay}(A_4, S_3)\}$

4 Comparing the Two Criteria

The two criteria use the same payoff table but emphasize different aspects of the decision.

	Maximax	Maximin
Focus	Best possible payoff	Worst possible payoff
Decision rule	Choose the alternative with the highest possible payoff	Choose the alternative with the highest worst-case payoff
Attitude	Optimistic	Conservative
Risk	Accepts greater uncertainty in pursuit of a high payoff	Places greater emphasis on protection against poor outcomes
Use when	The decision-maker focuses on favorable possibilities	The decision-maker wants protection against unfavorable possibilities

A decision-maker using **Maximax** asks:

“What is the best that could happen?”

A decision-maker using **Maximin** asks:

“What is the worst that could happen, and which alternative handles it best?”

5 Contextualized 2x2 Problem - Coffee shop

A small coffee shop is considering whether to introduce a new dessert line or keep its current menu. The manager knows that the level of customer traffic during the promotional weekend is uncertain and has no reliable information about the probability of high or low traffic.

What would a perfectly logical and optimistic decision-maker choose? What would a perfectly logical and pessimistic decision-maker choose?

Alternative	High traffic (S_1)	Low traffic (S_2)
Launch dessert line (A_1)	42	8
Keep current menu (A_2)	28	20

All payoffs are expressed in thousands of dollars.

Determine the decision using both the Maximax and Maximin criteria.

5.1 Solution

Step 1: Identify the alternatives and states of nature

Alternatives: A_1 = Launch dessert line, A_2 = Keep current menu States of nature: S_1 = High traffic, S_2 = Low traffic.

Step 2: Calculate the Maximax values

For each alternative, identify its highest possible payoff:

$$M_1 = \max\{42, 8\} = 42,$$

$$M_2 = \max\{28, 20\} = 28.$$

Compare the two maximum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximax}}^* = \arg \max_i M_i = A_1.$$

Thus, the Maximax criterion recommends launching the dessert line because it offers the highest possible payoff.

Step 3: Calculate the Maximin values

For each alternative, identify its lowest possible payoff:

$$m_1 = \min\{42, 8\} = 8,$$

$$m_2 = \min\{28, 20\} = 20.$$

Compare the two minimum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximin}}^* = \arg \max_i m_i = A_2.$$

Thus, the Maximin criterion recommends keeping the current menu because it provides the highest worst-case payoff.

Extended payoff table

Alternative	S_1	S_2	Max	Min
A_1 : Launch dessert line	42	8	$\max\{42, 8\} = 42$	$\min\{42, 8\} = 8$
A_2 : Keep current menu	28	20	$\max\{28, 20\} = 28$	$\min\{28, 20\} = 20$

6 Contextualized 2x2 Problem - Clothing store

A local clothing store is deciding whether to launch a new advertising campaign before the holiday season or continue with its current marketing strategy. The manager knows that customer response to the campaign is uncertain and has no reliable information about the probability of strong or weak sales.

What would a perfectly logical and optimistic decision-maker choose? What would a perfectly logical and pessimistic decision-maker choose?

Alternative	Strong sales (S_1)	Weak sales (S_2)
Launch new campaign (A_1)	55	5
Keep current strategy (A_2)	35	22

All payoffs are expressed in thousands of dollars.

Determine the decision using both the Maximax and Maximin criteria.

6.1 Solution**Step 1: Identify the alternatives and states of nature**

Alternatives: A_1 = Launch new campaign, A_2 = Keep current strategy States of nature: S_1 = Strong sales, S_2 = Weak sales.

Step 2: Calculate the Maximax values

For each alternative, identify its highest possible payoff:

$$M_1 = \max\{55, 5\} = 55,$$

$$M_2 = \max\{35, 22\} = 35.$$

Compare the two maximum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximax}}^* = \arg \max_i M_i = A_1.$$

Thus, the Maximax criterion recommends launching the new campaign because it offers the highest possible payoff.

Step 3: Calculate the Maximin values

For each alternative, identify its lowest possible payoff:

$$m_1 = \min\{55, 5\} = 5,$$

$$m_2 = \min\{35, 22\} = 22.$$

Compare the two minimum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximin}}^* = \arg \max_i m_i = A_2.$$

Thus, the Maximin criterion recommends keeping the current strategy because it provides the highest worst-case payoff.

Extended payoff table

Alternative	S_1	S_2	Max	Min
A_1 : Launch new campaign	55	5	$\max\{55, 5\} = 55$	$\min\{55, 5\} = 5$
A_2 : Keep current strategy	35	22	$\max\{35, 22\} = 35$	$\min\{35, 22\} = 22$

7 Contextualized 4x3 Problem - Technology company

A technology company is deciding which product strategy to adopt for the launch of a new device. The manager knows that market conditions are uncertain and has no reliable information about the probability of each possible level of demand. The company is considering four possible strategies: launching a premium version, launching a standard version, launching a budget version, or delaying the launch.

The level of market demand could be high, medium, or low. The estimated profit for each strategy under each possible market condition is shown in the table below.

What would a perfectly logical and optimistic decision-maker choose? What would a perfectly logical and pessimistic decision-maker choose?

Alternative	High demand (S_1)	Medium demand (S_2)	Low demand (S_3)
Premium version (A_1)	80	35	-20
Standard version (A_2)	60	42	18
Budget version (A_3)	40	32	25
Delay launch (A_4)	15	15	15

All payoffs are expressed in thousands of dollars.

Determine the decision using both the Maximax and Maximin criteria.

7.1 Solution

Step 1: Identify the alternatives and states of nature

Alternatives: A_1 = Premium version, A_2 = Standard version, A_3 = Budget version, A_4 = Delay launch

States of nature: S_1 = High demand, S_2 = Medium demand, S_3 = Low demand.

Step 2: Calculate the Maximax values

For each alternative, identify its highest possible payoff:

$$M_1 = \max\{80, 35, -20\} = 80,$$

$$M_2 = \max\{60, 42, 18\} = 60,$$

$$M_3 = \max\{40, 32, 25\} = 40,$$

$$M_4 = \max\{15, 15, 15\} = 15.$$

Compare the four maximum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximax}}^* = \arg \max_i M_i = A_1.$$

Thus, the Maximax criterion recommends launching the premium version because it offers the highest possible payoff.

Step 3: Calculate the Maximin values

For each alternative, identify its lowest possible payoff:

$$m_1 = \min\{80, 35, -20\} = -20,$$

$$m_2 = \min\{60, 42, 18\} = 18,$$

$$m_3 = \min\{40, 32, 25\} = 25,$$

$$m_4 = \min\{15, 15, 15\} = 15.$$

Compare the four minimum values:

$$A_{\text{Maximin}}^* = \arg \max_i m_i = A_3.$$

Thus, the Maximin criterion recommends launching the budget version because it provides the highest worst-case payoff.

Extended payoff table

Alternative	S_1	S_2	S_3	Max	Min
A_1 : Premium version	80	35	-20	$\max\{80, 35, -20\} = 80$	$\min\{80, 35, -20\} = -20$
A_2 : Standard version	60	42	18	$\max\{60, 42, 18\} = 60$	$\min\{60, 42, 18\} = 18$
A_3 : Budget version	40	32	25	$\max\{40, 32, 25\} = 40$	$\min\{40, 32, 25\} = 25$
A_4 : Delay launch	15	15	15	$\max\{15, 15, 15\} = 15$	$\min\{15, 15, 15\} = 15$